

CHURCH BUSINESS MEETING

Role Definition, Terms of Reference (TORs) & Operating Manual

Seventh-day Adventist Church

1. Purpose of This Document

This document helps the local church understand, organize, and faithfully conduct its Church Business Meetings according to the Church Manual.

It translates the Church Manual's expectations into practical workflows, routines, templates, and checklists so that the church can exercise its authority in an orderly, representative, mission-focused, and well-documented manner.

This document answers five practical questions:

1. What is the Church Business Meeting responsible for?
 2. Who calls, chairs, attends, and votes in the meeting?
 3. What matters should come to a Business Meeting?
 4. What reports, plans, budgets, elections, and membership actions must be handled there?
 5. How should the Business Meeting relate to the Church Board, pastor, conference, and members?
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2. Manual Alignment Principle

This operating manual is governed by three rules:

1. No responsibility should be assigned to the Church Business Meeting unless it is grounded in the Church Manual.
2. All duties and procedures must map to the Manual's logic on representation, membership, elections, meetings, reports, finance, Board authority, and conference relationship.
3. Where this document proposes templates, registers, calendars, or checklists, these are operating tools designed to help the church faithfully execute Manual-based responsibilities. They are not new sources of authority.

In this document:

- **Manual requirement** means the duty is directly stated or clearly required by the Church Manual.

- **Operating tool** means a practical template, checklist, or rhythm that helps execute a Manual requirement.
 - **Local adaptation** means the church may adjust the format without changing the Manual's requirements.
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3. The Church Business Meeting

3.1 Why the Business Meeting Matters

The Church Business Meeting is the constituency meeting of the local church. It is the formal setting in which members in regular standing exercise their voice and vote in the life and governance of the local congregation.

It is the meeting through which the local church receives reports, approves major plans, acts on matters requiring church authority, and holds the Church Board accountable within the boundaries of the Church Manual.

3.2 Core Identity of the Meeting

The Church Business Meeting is:

- The constituency meeting of the local church
- The highest local meeting authority under the Church Manual
- The body with authority over the Church Board
- The body that elects officers and Board members through the appropriate election process
- The body that receives annual reports about the work of the church
- The body that approves the proposed plan of action for the next year, including the annual budget
- The body that takes final action on major items requiring church action

3.3 Operating Posture of the Meeting

The Business Meeting should be conducted with:

- Order
- Prayerfulness
- Transparency
- Proper notice
- Respect for member voice
- Faithfulness to the Church Manual
- Cooperation with the pastor and conference
- Written records preserved by the Clerk

4. Guiding Principles

4.1 The Business Meeting Is the Church Acting in Session

Within the context of the local church's role in the wider Seventh-day Adventist structure, the Business Meeting is the local church's constituency meeting.

Members in regular standing are encouraged to attend and are entitled to vote. A member under censure does not have the right to participate by voice or vote.

4.2 The Business Meeting Has Authority Over the Board

The Business Meeting has authority over the Church Board and may delegate responsibilities to the Board in addition to those already assigned by the Church Manual.

This means the Board remains accountable to the church in Business Meeting and does not replace it.

4.3 Major Items Belong in the Business Meeting

Major items should be decided at a regular or specially called Business Meeting.

This includes matters that require church action, broad church approval, or formal adoption by the membership.

4.4 The Meeting Must Be Properly Called and Announced

Business Meetings are called by the pastor, or by the Board in consultation with and support of the pastor.

They should be announced one or two weeks in advance at the regular Sabbath worship service, with details as to time and place.

4.5 The Business Meeting Must Receive Reports

The agenda should include reports about the work of the church.

At least once each year, the agenda should include reports covering church activities. Based on those reports, a proposed plan of action for the next year, including an annual budget, should be presented for approval.

Where possible, reports and plans for the next year should be presented in writing.

4.6 The Church Must Cooperate With the Conference

In order to maintain a spirit of cooperation between the church and conference, the church must secure counsel from conference officers on all major matters.

Conference and union officers may attend Business Meetings without vote unless granted voting rights by the church, or unless they are already members of that congregation.

4.7 Votes by Proxy or Letter Are Not Permitted

Members may participate and vote only according to the Manual's permitted meeting process. Votes by proxy or letter are not permitted.

5. Formal Responsibilities of the Church Business Meeting

The Business Meeting's responsibilities fall into nine major areas:

1. Exercising local church authority
2. Receiving reports on the work of the church
3. Approving the proposed plan of action
4. Approving the annual budget through the proper process
5. Electing officers and Board members through the election process
6. Acting on membership matters that require church vote
7. Establishing quorum and meeting procedures where required
8. Delegating responsibilities to the Board where appropriate
9. Maintaining cooperation with the conference on major matters

Each area is described below.

6. Membership and Voting

6.1 Members Entitled to Attend and Vote

Members in regular standing are encouraged to attend and are entitled to vote.

A member under censure has no right to participate by voice or vote.

6.2 Quorum

Each church decides what the quorum will be for future Business Meetings.

The quorum should be adopted by the church and recorded clearly so that future meetings can determine whether business may proceed.

6.3 Electronic Participation

Where authorized by the conference executive committee and approved by the church, members may participate in Business Meetings by electronic conference or similar

communication, provided all participants can communicate with one another at the same time.

Such participation counts as presence in person at the meeting.

6.4 Voting Constraints

Votes by proxy or letter are not permitted.

The Business Meeting must protect the integrity of member voice, discussion, and voting.

7. Calling, Notice, and Chairing the Meeting

7.1 Calling the Meeting

Business Meetings are called by:

- The pastor; or
- The Church Board in consultation with and support of the pastor

7.2 Notice of Meeting

Business Meetings should be announced one or two weeks in advance at the regular Sabbath worship service.

The announcement should include:

- Date
- Time
- Place
- Purpose or major agenda items where appropriate

7.3 Chairperson

The chairperson of the Business Meeting is:

- The pastor; or
- An elder chosen by the pastor; or
- In some cases, the conference president or designee

The chairperson guides the meeting so that the church acts in an orderly and properly constituted manner.

8. Agenda and Business Items

8.1 Standard Business Meeting Agenda

A Business Meeting agenda may include:

- Opening prayer or devotional thought
- Confirmation of previous minutes
- Reports on the work of the church
- Membership matters requiring church action
- Election-related matters
- Recommendations from the Board
- Financial reports and budget matters
- Proposed plan of action
- Major matters requiring church decision
- Closing prayer

8.2 Annual Reports

At least once each year, the Business Meeting agenda should include reports covering church activities.

Reports should help the church understand:

- What work has been done
- What progress has been made
- What needs remain
- What plans are proposed for the next year

8.3 Proposed Plan of Action

Based on the reports received, a proposed plan of action for the next year should be presented for approval.

The plan should be written where possible and should show how the church intends to carry forward its mission.

8.4 Annual Budget

The proposed plan of action should include an annual budget.

The budget should reach the Business Meeting through the proper process, including review or recommendation by the finance process, the Church Board, and then action by the church.

8.5 Major Matters

Major items should be decided at a regular or specially called Business Meeting.

Where a matter is major enough to affect the church's direction, finances, membership, property, or long-term obligations, it should not be handled casually or informally.

9. Relationship to the Church Board

9.1 Board Accountability

The Business Meeting has authority over the Church Board.

The Board should bring appropriate reports, recommendations, plans, budgets, and major matters to the Business Meeting for action.

9.2 Delegating Responsibility to the Board

The Business Meeting may delegate responsibilities to the Board in addition to those assigned by the Church Manual.

Such delegation should be clearly recorded in the minutes.

9.3 Board Recommendations to the Church

The Board may recommend matters to the Business Meeting, including:

- Membership transfers
- Membership removals where applicable
- Financial matters requiring church action
- Budget approval
- Annual plans
- Committee recommendations
- Major local church initiatives

9.4 Limits of Board Authority

The Board must not treat its recommendations as final church action where the Church Manual requires action by the church.

The Business Meeting is therefore a safeguard against unauthorized concentration of authority in the Board.

10. Elections and Officer Selection

10.1 Election Process

Officers are elected every one or two years through an appointed nominating committee.

In exceptional circumstances, and in consultation with the conference, the term of office may be extended an additional year.

10.2 Nominating Committee Report

The nominating committee brings its report to the church, which votes on the names presented.

The Business Meeting or properly called church setting receives the report according to the Manual's process.

10.3 Members' Right to Appear Before the Nominating Committee

Members desiring to appear before the nominating committee to make suggestions or objections should be given opportunity to do so according to the Manual's process.

After they have addressed the committee and retired from the room, the committee considers their comments and reports to the church.

10.4 Objections to the Nominating Committee Report

Members may object to the nominating committee's report.

The objection should follow the proper process and may result in the matter being referred back to the committee for further consideration.

10.5 Filling Vacancies Between Elections

If an office becomes vacant during the term of office, the Board may nominate a successor to fill the vacancy for the remainder of the term and submit the nomination to the church for election.

11. Membership Matters Requiring Church Action

11.1 Transfers of Membership

Final action on membership transfers belongs to the church.

The Board may recommend favorably or otherwise, but the church acts on transfers.

11.2 Removal From Membership

Removal from membership for discipline is the ultimate discipline the church can administer and must follow the Manual's process.

The Board may recommend action, but final disciplinary action belongs to a properly called meeting of the church.

11.3 Removal at Death or Member Request

The Church Manual provides specific processes for recording removal at death or at a member's written request.

The Business Meeting should not create additional procedures that contradict the Manual.

12. Conference Relationship

12.1 Counsel on Major Matters

The church must secure counsel from conference officers on all major matters.

The Business Meeting should not treat major decisions as purely local if the Manual calls for cooperation with the conference.

12.2 Conference and Union Officers Attending

Conference and union officers or their designees may attend any Business Meeting in their territory without vote unless granted by the church.

If the officer is already a member of that congregation, no action is required to allow voting.

12.3 Conference Role in Electronic Participation

Electronic participation in Business Meetings requires authorization by the conference executive committee and approval by the church.

The conference provides guidance on basic principles and technical solutions.

13. Operating Calendar

13.1 Annual Minimum Rhythm

Every church must hold a Business Meeting at least once a year.

At least once each year, the Business Meeting should receive reports covering church activities and approve a proposed plan of action for the next year, including an annual budget.

13.2 Regular Business Meeting Rhythm

The church may hold additional Business Meetings as needed to handle major items, membership actions, election matters, budgets, reports, and other matters requiring church authority.

13.3 Specially Called Business Meetings

Specially called Business Meetings should be used when a major matter requires timely church action before the next regular Business Meeting.

Notice should be given one or two weeks in advance at the regular Sabbath worship service, with details as to time and place.

14. Detailed Standard Operating Procedures

SOP 1: Calling a Business Meeting

Trigger: Annual meeting due or major item requiring church action.

Authority Check: Meeting is called by the pastor, or by the Board in consultation with and support of the pastor.

Steps: 1. Confirm the need for a Business Meeting. 2. Confirm who will call the meeting. 3. Confirm chairperson. 4. Prepare notice with date, time, place, and major purpose. 5. Announce one or two weeks in advance at the regular Sabbath worship service. 6. Prepare agenda and documents.

Output: Properly called and announced Business Meeting.

SOP 2: Preparing the Agenda

Trigger: Business Meeting scheduled.

Authority Check: Agenda items must be appropriate for church action.

Steps: 1. Review Board recommendations requiring church action. 2. Identify membership matters requiring vote. 3. Gather reports to be received. 4. Include annual reports and plan of action when applicable. 5. Include annual budget when applicable. 6. Prepare written reports and plans where possible. 7. Confirm agenda with chairperson.

Output: Business Meeting agenda pack.

SOP 3: Verifying Voting Participation

Trigger: Business Meeting held.

Authority Check: Voting is limited to members in regular standing.

Steps: 1. Confirm attendance method. 2. Confirm whether quorum is met. 3. Ensure members under censure do not participate by voice or vote. 4. Ensure no votes are accepted by proxy or letter. 5. If electronic participation is used, confirm conference authorization and church approval.

Output: Valid participation and voting record.

SOP 4: Conducting the Business Meeting

Trigger: Business Meeting begins.

Authority Check: Proper chairperson presides.

Steps: 1. Open with prayer or devotional focus. 2. Confirm quorum. 3. Follow the agenda. 4. Receive reports. 5. Present recommendations and motions clearly. 6. Allow orderly member participation. 7. Vote on matters requiring church action. 8. Ensure Clerk records actions accurately.

Output: Completed Business Meeting with valid actions.

SOP 5: Acting on Board Recommendations

Trigger: Board recommendation presented to the church.

Authority Check: Matter requires or permits church action.

Steps: 1. Present recommendation clearly. 2. Clarify whether the matter is for approval, election, referral, or information. 3. Allow appropriate discussion. 4. Take vote where required. 5. Record final action exactly. 6. Assign follow-up responsibility.

Output: Church action on Board recommendation.

SOP 6: Receiving Annual Reports and Approving Next-Year Plan

Trigger: Annual Business Meeting.

Authority Check: Reports and plans are presented to the church for review and approval where required.

Steps: 1. Receive reports covering church activities. 2. Review progress and needs. 3. Present proposed plan of action for next year. 4. Present annual budget as part of the plan. 5. Allow questions and clarification. 6. Vote on adoption where required. 7. Record action.

Output: Approved plan of action and annual budget.

SOP 7: Handling Election Matters

Trigger: Regular election cycle or vacancy.

Authority Check: Nominating committee process followed; church votes on names presented.

Steps: 1. Confirm election cycle or vacancy. 2. Receive nominating committee report or Board nomination for vacancy. 3. Follow the Manual's process for objections where applicable. 4. Vote on nominees. 5. Record elected officers. 6. Ensure handover process begins where needed.

Output: Elected officers or filled vacancy.

SOP 8: Seeking Conference Counsel on Major Matters

Trigger: Major matter arises.

Authority Check: Manual requires counsel from conference officers on all major matters.

Steps: 1. Identify why the matter is major. 2. Refer matter to pastor and Board for coordination. 3. Seek counsel from conference officers. 4. Record counsel received where appropriate. 5. Present matter to Business Meeting only after proper preparation. 6. Record final church action.

Output: Major matter handled in cooperation with conference.

15. Templates and Registers

15.1 Business Meeting Agenda Template

- Church:
- Date:
- Time:
- Venue:
- Chairperson:
- Clerk:

Agenda 1. Opening prayer / devotion 2. Confirmation of quorum 3. Previous minutes 4. Reports received 5. Board recommendations 6. Membership actions 7. Financial matters / budget 8. Elections or vacancies 9. Major matters requiring church action 10. Closing prayer

15.2 Business Meeting Minutes Template

- Church:

- Date:
- Time:
- Venue:
- Chairperson:
- Clerk / Recording Secretary:
- Attendance / Number present:
- Quorum confirmed: Yes / No

Actions Taken

Item	Motion / Recommendation	Action Taken	Responsible Person	Deadline
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15.3 Annual Reports Register

Department / Officer	Report Received	Written Report Filed	Action Required	Follow-Up
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15.4 Business Meeting Action Register

Date	Decision	Authority	Assigned To	Due Date	Status
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15.5 Board Recommendation Tracker

Recommendation	Board Date	Business Meeting Date	Outcome	Follow-Up
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15.6 Conference Counsel Record

Matter	Date Counsel Sought	Conference Officer	Counsel Received	Action Taken
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16. Checklists

16.1 Before Business Meeting

- ☐ Meeting properly called
- ☐ Notice announced one or two weeks in advance
- ☐ Date, time, and place communicated
- ☐ Chairperson confirmed
- ☐ Agenda prepared
- ☐ Reports gathered
- ☐ Board recommendations prepared
- ☐ Membership items verified

- ☐ Budget / plan documents prepared where applicable
- ☐ Quorum requirement known

16.2 During Business Meeting

- ☐ Quorum confirmed
- ☐ Members in regular standing participate and vote
- ☐ No proxy or letter votes accepted
- ☐ Reports received
- ☐ Motions and actions clearly stated
- ☐ Votes taken where required
- ☐ Clerk records actions accurately

16.3 After Business Meeting

- ☐ Minutes drafted
- ☐ Actions entered into action register
- ☐ Membership records updated where applicable
- ☐ Officers / committees notified
- ☐ Board follow-up items identified
- ☐ Documents filed

16.4 Annual Business Meeting Checklist

- ☐ Reports covering church activities received
- ☐ Proposed plan of action presented
- ☐ Annual budget presented
- ☐ Written reports used where possible
- ☐ Church action recorded
- ☐ Next-year execution responsibilities assigned

16.5 Major Matter Checklist

- ☐ Matter identified as major
- ☐ Board reviewed matter
- ☐ Conference counsel sought
- ☐ Documents prepared
- ☐ Business Meeting properly called
- ☐ Church action recorded

17. First 90 Days for a Newly Organized Business Meeting System

Days 1–30

- Confirm quorum previously adopted by the church

- Confirm current Business Meeting notice practice
- Review previous Business Meeting minutes
- Review pending items requiring church action
- Confirm who chairs meetings when pastor is unavailable
- Confirm whether electronic participation has been authorized and approved

Days 31–60

- Establish Business Meeting action register
- Establish annual reports calendar
- Review Board recommendation flow
- Review annual budget approval pathway
- Confirm procedure for membership actions requiring church vote

Days 61–90

- Prepare draft annual Business Meeting calendar
- Prepare standard agenda and minutes templates
- Review conference counsel process for major matters
- Orient Board and Clerk on Business Meeting workflows
- Identify upcoming matters requiring church action

18. What Good Business Meeting Function Looks Like

A strong Church Business Meeting is properly called, well prepared, clearly chaired, faithfully recorded, and focused on matters that require church authority.

It receives reports, approves plans and budgets, elects officers, acts on membership matters, and holds the Board accountable without becoming disorderly or overreaching beyond the Church Manual.

19. Risks if the Business Meeting Function Is Weak

If the Business Meeting is weak, the church may experience:

- Major decisions made without proper authority
- Board overreach
- Poor member participation
- Unclear or disputed decisions
- Weak annual planning
- Budget approval without proper process

- Improper handling of membership matters
 - Elections handled without adequate process
 - Lack of conference counsel on major matters
 - Loss of confidence in church governance
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20. Suggested Appendices to Add Later

1. Sample Business Meeting agenda
 2. Sample Business Meeting minutes
 3. Annual reports packet template
 4. Board recommendation form
 5. Membership action form
 6. Annual plan of action template
 7. Budget approval workflow
 8. Quorum adoption record
 9. Special Business Meeting notice template
 10. Conference counsel request template
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21. Closing Note

The Church Business Meeting is not merely an administrative gathering. It is the local church acting in its formal capacity under the Church Manual.

When it works well, members participate responsibly, the Board remains accountable, major decisions are made properly, and the church's mission is strengthened through order, transparency, and shared responsibility.

The Business Meeting protects the church from both disorder and unchecked authority. It gives the local congregation a proper voice in the work God has entrusted to it.